

confprogbook — A L^AT_EX class for conference program books

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Abstract

The `confprogbook` class provides a complete, ready-to-use solution for typesetting conference *Book of Abstracts* or *Program Books*. It is built on the standard `book` class and offers high-level commands for cover pages, programmatic tables of contents with dotted leaders, session and talk entries, PDF abstract inclusion, participant lists, and organizational comments — all with customizable colors. The class was originally developed for the Benelux Meeting on Systems and Control and has been generalized for use by any academic conference.

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1 Introduction

Organizing a conference often requires producing a *Book of Abstracts*: a printed or PDF booklet that contains the program schedule, all submitted paper abstracts (as included PDFs), a list of participants, and practical information.

The `confprogbook` class encapsulates years of experience producing such books into a single, easy-to-use $\text{\LaTeX}$ class. Instead of manually configuring dozens of packages and defining custom commands, you simply write:

```
\documentclass[a4paper]{confprogbook}
\conferencetitle{10th International Symposium on Examples}
\conferencedate{June 1--3, 2027}
\conferencelocation{Zurich, Switzerland}
```

and the class takes care of page layout, headers/footers, colors, and provides all the commands you need.

1.1 Features

- Automatic cover page and front matter generation.
- Colored, boxed headings for days, plenary talks, and sessions.
- Programmatic table of contents with dotted leaders and page references.
- Simple command to include paper PDFs with auto-labeling.
- Participant list formatting with email `mailto:` links.
- Landscape program overview tables with accent colors.
- Fully customizable color scheme.
- Compatible with pdf $\text{\LaTeX}$, Lua $\text{\LaTeX}$, and Xe $\text{\LaTeX}$.

1.2 License

This work is released under the $\text{\LaTeX}$ Project Public License v1.3c or later. See <https://www.latex-project.org/lppl/>.

2 Quick Start

Below is a minimal working example that produces a complete conference program book.

```
\documentclass[a4paper]{confprogbook}

%% --- Conference metadata ---
\conferencetitle{10th International Symposium on Examples}
\conferencedate{June 1--3, 2027}
\conferencelocation{Zurich, Switzerland}
\conferenceshort{ISE 2027}
\booktitle{Book of Abstracts}
\editors{Alice Smith, Bob Jones, and Carol Lee}
\institution{ETH Zurich}
\institutionaddress{Zurich, Switzerland}
\conferencelogo[0.15]{logo.png}

\begin{document}

%% --- Front matter ---
\makefrontcover
\makefrontmatter
```

```

%% --- Program ---
\cpbbeginprogram
\input{program}      % your program entries
\programpartindex    % automatic part index
\cpbendprogram

%% --- Abstracts ---
\cpbbeginabstracts
\input{abstracts}    % \includepaper commands
\cpbendabstracts

%% --- Participants ---
\cpbbeginparticipants
\input{participants} % \putpart commands
\cpbendparticipants

%% --- Comments ---
\cpbbegincomments
\input{comments}     % free-form LaTeX content
\cpbendcomments

\end{document}

```

3 Class Options

The confprogbook class is built on the standard book class. All options are forwarded directly to book. Common choices:

```

\documentclass[a4paper]{confprogbook}    % A4 (default recommended)
\documentclass[letterpaper]{confprogbook} % US Letter
\documentclass[a4paper,12pt]{confprogbook} % Larger base font

```

4 Conference Metadata

All metadata commands should be called in the preamble, before `\begin{document}`. They configure the cover page, headers, and PDF metadata.

Command	Description
<code>\conferencetitle{<i>text</i>}</code>	Main conference title (shown on cover).
<code>\conferencesubtitle{<i>text</i>}</code>	Optional subtitle, shown below the title.
<code>\conferenceedition{<i>text</i>}</code>	Edition string, e.g., 45th.
<code>\conferencedate{<i>text</i>}</code>	Conference dates.
<code>\conferencelocation{<i>text</i>}</code>	Venue / city / country.
<code>\conferenceshort{<i>text</i>}</code>	Short name used in page headers.
<code>\booktitle{<i>text</i>}</code>	Title of the book (default: <i>Book of Abstracts</i>).
<code>\editors{<i>text</i>}</code>	Editor names for the front matter page.
<code>\institution{<i>text</i>}</code>	Publishing institution name.
<code>\institutionaddress{<i>text</i>}</code>	Institution address.
<code>\copyrightnotice{<i>text</i>}</code>	Custom copyright text.
<code>\conferencelogo[<i>scale</i>]{<i>file</i>}</code>	Logo image file and optional scale (default 0.2).
<code>\pdfscale{<i>value</i>}</code>	Scale factor for included abstract PDFs (default 0.95).

5 Document Structure Commands

The class provides high-level commands that set up each major section of the book. Use them in order inside `\begin{document}... \end{document}`.

5.1 Cover and Front Matter

`\makefrontcover`

Generates the title page using the metadata you defined. Includes conference title, subtitle, dates, location, and book title.

`\makefrontmatter`

Generates the second page with the logo, editor names, book title, institution, and copyright notice.

5.2 Program

`\cpbbeginprogram`

Opens the program section: inserts a “Part 1” divider page, switches to two-column mode, and activates fancy headers. After this, include your program content (day headings, session headings, talk entries).

`\programpartindex`

Convenience macro that outputs the standard four-part index (Program, Abstracts, Participants, Comments) with dotted leaders. Call this after your program content and before `\cpbendprogram`.

`\cpbendprogram`

Closes the program section.

5.3 Abstracts

`\cpbbeginabstracts`

Opens the abstracts section with a “Part 2” divider page and switches to one-column mode.

`\cpbendabstracts`

Closes the abstracts section.

5.4 Participants

`\cpbbeginparticipants`

Opens the participant list section with a “Part 3” divider page and switches to two-column mode.

`\cpbendparticipants`

Closes the participant list section and starts a new page.

5.5 Comments / Organizational Info

`\cpbbegincomments`

Opens the comments section (“Part 4”) in one-column mode. This section typically contains free-form L^AT_EX content: welcome text, practical info, landscape schedule tables, venue maps, etc.

`\cpbendcomments`

Closes the comments section.

6 Program Entry Commands

These commands typeset the individual entries within the program section.

6.1 `\dayheading` — Day Separator

```
\dayheading{Tuesday, March 24, 2026}
```

Produces a full-width colored box (using the “day” color scheme) with the day title centered in bold. Automatically inserts a page break before the heading.

6.2 `\pleheading` — Plenary Session Heading

```
\pleheading{Plenary}{Fagus}{Data-Enabled Predictive Control}  
{Florian Doerfler}{Raphael Jungers}{11:15--12:15}
```

Six arguments:

1. $\langle type \rangle$ — e.g., “Plenary” (can be empty).
2. $\langle room \rangle$ — room name.
3. $\langle title \rangle$ — talk/event title.
4. $\langle speaker \rangle$ — speaker name (can be empty).
5. $\langle chair \rangle$ — session chair.
6. $\langle time \rangle$ — time slot.

6.3 `\sesheading` — Regular Session Heading

```
\sesheading{TueA01}{Fagus}  
{Neuromorphic Systems and Control I}  
{Rodolphe Sepulchre}{13:15--15:35}
```

Five arguments: $\langle code \rangle$, $\langle room \rangle$, $\langle title \rangle$, $\langle chair \rangle$, $\langle time \rangle$.

6.4 `\puttalk` — Individual Talk Entry

```
\puttalk{TueA01-1\hfill 13.15-13.35}
{\puttalktitle{Inferring Neuromodulatory Targets}{paper700}}
{Julien Brandoit}{University of Liege}
{Pierre Sacre}{University of Liege}
{Damien Ernst}{University of Liege}
{Julien Brandoit}
```

Nine arguments:

1. $\langle ID + time \rangle$ — talk code and time slot (use `\hfill` to right-align time).
2. $\langle title\ line \rangle$ — typically a `\puttalktitle` call.
3. $\langle author1 \rangle$ — first author name.
4. $\langle affil1 \rangle$ — first author affiliation.
5. $\langle author2 \rangle$ — second author (empty string `{}` if none).
6. $\langle affil2 \rangle$ — second author affiliation.
7. $\langle author3 \rangle$ — third author.
8. $\langle affil3 \rangle$ — third author affiliation.
9. $\langle presenter \rangle$ — presenting author name.

Leave unused author/affiliation pairs as `{}``{}`.

6.5 `\puttalktitle` — Talk Title with Page Reference

```
\puttalktitle{My Talk Title}{paper700}
```

Two arguments: $\langle title \rangle$ and $\langle label \rangle$. Produces an italicized title with dotted leaders to the page where the corresponding abstract PDF begins (matching the label set by `\includepaper`).

6.6 `\putplen` — Part Entry in Program Index

```
\putplen{Part 1: Programmatic Table of Contents}
{Overview of scientific program}{P:1}
```

Three arguments: $\langle title \rangle$, $\langle subtitle \rangle$, $\langle label \rangle$.

7 Abstract Inclusion

7.1 `\includepaper` — Include a Paper PDF

```
\includepaper{paper700}{pdf/bmsc2026_700.pdf}
```

Two mandatory arguments:

1. $\langle label \rangle$ — a unique label (used by `\puttalktitle` for page references).
2. $\langle filepath \rangle$ — path to the PDF file.

Optional argument for custom scale:

```
\includepaper[0.90]{paper700}{pdf/bmsc2026_700.pdf}
```

If omitted, the global `\pdfscale` value is used (default: 0.95). Each included PDF gets the fancy page style and increments the internal PDF page counter.

8 Participant List

8.1 \putpart — Participant Entry

```
\putpart{}{Alice Smith}{ETH Zurich}{}{alice@ethz.ch}
```

Five arguments:

1. $\langle prefix \rangle$ — optional prefix (e.g., “Prof.”).
2. $\langle name \rangle$ — participant name.
3. $\langle affiliation \rangle$ — institution.
4. $\langle extra \rangle$ — additional info (can be empty).
5. $\langle email \rangle$ — email address (rendered as a `mailto:` link; leave empty to omit).

9 Color Customization

The class defines three color groups, each with fill, frame, and text colors. Customize them in the preamble.

9.1 Commands

Each setter takes three arguments. Each argument is a color specification in the form `{model}{value}`, exactly as you would pass to `\definecolor`.

```
% Dark blue theme for day headings
\setdaycolors
{rgb}{0.1, 0.2, 0.5}    % fill
{rgb}{0.05, 0.1, 0.3}   % frame
{gray}{1}               % text (white)

% Gold plenary theme
\setplenarycolors
{rgb}{0.85, 0.65, 0.13} % fill
{rgb}{0.72, 0.53, 0.04} % frame
{gray}{0}               % text (black)

% Light gray session theme
\setsessioncolors
{gray}{0.9}
{gray}{0.6}
{gray}{0}

% Table accent column color
\settableaccentcolor{rgb}{0.9, 0.95, 1.0}
```

9.2 Default Colors

Group	Fill	Frame	Text
Day	<code>rgb{1,.2,.2}</code> (red)	same as fill	<code>gray{0}</code> (black)
Plenary	<code>rgb{.4,0,.8}</code> (purple)	same as fill	<code>gray{1}</code> (white)
Session	<code>rgb{.8,.8,1}</code> (light blue)	same as fill	<code>gray{0}</code> (black)

10 Landscape Program Tables

The comments section often includes landscape overview tables. The class provides helpers for this:

`\setlandscapecolwidth{<length>}`

Set the width of landscape tables (default: 244mm).

`\rr` Shorthand for `\raggedright`, useful inside `tabularx` cells.

`\accentcol`

Column specifier prefix for accent-colored columns. Use as: `\begin{tabularx}{\cpb@colw}{\acce`

```
\begin{landscape}
\vfll
\centerline{\large\textbf{Tuesday, March 24, 2026}}
\begin{tabularx}{244mm}{\accentcol lX|X|X|Xl|}
\hline
Room & Fagus & Salix & Populus & \\\
...
\end{tabularx}
\vfll
\end{landscape}
```

11 Utility Commands

`\euros{<amount>}`

Formats a euro amount: `\euros{600}` renders as “€ 600”.

`\RED{<text>}`

Highlights text in the highlight color (default red).

`\programskip`

Shorthand for `\medskip\nopagebreak`, the most common spacing pattern between program entries.

12 Customizing Part Names

If you want to rename the four standard parts (e.g., to a different language), use:

```
\setpartname{I}{Partie 1}{Table des matieres programmatique}
\setpartname{II}{Partie 2}{Resumes}
\setpartname{III}{Partie 3}{Liste des participants}
\setpartname{IV}{Partie 4}{Informations pratiques}
```

Note: this currently sets internal macros. The high-level structure commands (`\cpbbeginprogram`, etc.) use hardcoded English strings for the divider pages. For full localization, override the structure commands or redefine them after loading the class.

13 Package Dependencies

The class automatically loads the following packages. You do *not* need to load them yourself.

Package	Purpose
amsmath, amssymb, amstext	Math support
graphicx	Image inclusion
xcolor (with table option)	Color support
latexsym	Additional symbols
ifthen, etoolbox	Conditionals
tabularx, ltablex	Flexible tables
lscape	Landscape pages
fancyhdr	Custom headers/footers
pdfpages	PDF inclusion
fontenc (T1)	Font encoding
hyperref	Hyperlinks and PDF metadata
pgfkeys	Key-value processing
xparse	Extended command definitions

14 Migrating from a Manual Setup

If you have an existing conference book that uses manual `\newcommand` definitions (like the original Benelux Meeting setup), migration is straightforward:

1. Replace `\documentclass{book}` with `\documentclass[a4paper]{confprogbook}`.
2. Delete your package loading block — the class loads everything.
3. Delete your custom command definitions (`\dayheading`, `\pleheading`, `\sesheading`, etc.) — they are now provided by the class.
4. Delete your color definitions — the class provides defaults. Customize with `\setdaycolors` etc. if needed.
5. Delete your page layout settings — the class handles this.
6. Add metadata commands in the preamble (`\conferencetitle`, etc.).
7. Replace your manual section structure with the high-level commands (`\makefrontcover`, `\cpbbeginprogram`, etc.).
8. Replace long `\includepdf[...]` calls with `\includepaper{label}{file}`.
9. Your `\puttalk`, `\putpart`, and content files work *unchanged*.

15 Frequently Asked Questions

Can I use this with Lua^AT_EX or X_YLa^AT_EX? Yes. The class uses standard packages that work across all major engines. If using Lua^AT_EX/X_YLa^AT_EX, you may want to add `fontspec` in your document preamble for system fonts.

Can I add extra parts beyond the four standard ones? Yes. The structure commands are just convenience macros. You can freely add `\onecolumn`, `\twocolumn`, `\cleardoublepage`, etc. and create additional sections as needed.

Can I use this on Overleaf? Yes. Upload `confprogbook.cls` to your Overleaf project root (same directory as your `main.tex`) and it will be found automatically. See Section 16.2 for details.

How do I change the header text? Use `\conferenceshort` for the left/right header and `\booktitle` for the other side.

16 Publishing to CTAN and Overleaf

16.1 CTAN Submission

To make the class available to the entire L^AT_EX community via CTAN (Comprehensive T_EX Archive Network):

1. **Prepare the TDS-compliant archive:**

```
confprogbook/  
  confprogbook.cls  
  confprogbook-doc.tex  
  confprogbook-doc.pdf  
  README.md  
  LICENSE  
  example/  
    main.tex  
    program.tex  
    abstracts.tex  
    participants.tex  
    comments.tex
```

2. **Compile the documentation:**

```
pdflatex confprogbook-doc.tex  
pdflatex confprogbook-doc.tex
```

3. **Create a zip archive:**

```
zip -r confprogbook.zip confprogbook/
```

4. **Submit to CTAN:**

- Go to <https://ctan.org/upload>.
- Fill in the metadata: name (`confprogbook`), version, summary, license (LPPL 1.3c), author.
- Upload the zip file.
- CTAN volunteers will review and integrate the package (typically within a few days).

5. **TeX Live / MiKTeX integration:** Once on CTAN, the package will be picked up by TeX Live and MiKTeX in their next update cycle. Users can then install it via their package manager.

16.2 Overleaf Availability

Overleaf uses TeX Live, so once your package is on CTAN and included in TeX Live, it becomes automatically available on Overleaf. There are also faster paths:

1. **Immediate use (any project):** Upload `confprogbook.cls` directly into your Overleaf project.
2. **Overleaf template gallery:** Create a template project on Overleaf with the class and example files, then submit it to the [Overleaf Gallery](#) via **Submit to Gallery** in the project menu.
3. **Automatic via CTAN → TeX Live:** After CTAN acceptance and the next TeX Live update, users can use `\documentclass{confprogbook}` directly without uploading the `.cls` file.

17 Version History

v1.0 (2026/03/11) Initial release. All core functionality: metadata commands, structure commands, program entries, abstract inclusion, participant lists, color customization.

18 Acknowledgments

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